

THE OHIO STATE UNIVERSITY

COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING

Technical Communication Lab Assertion-Evidence Approach & PDR Presentation Preparation

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ECE 3906: Capstone Design 1

Assertion-Evidence Approach

Assertion-Evidence Approach

- The **assertion-evidence approach** is a strategy for making effective presentation visuals (slides).
- It aims to solve two common issues with presentation visuals:
  - Too much text on the slides
  - Bland slide titles
- It also aims to increase audience engagement.

Assertion-Evidence Approach

- The strategy is to break up your presentation into the most important assertions which tell the “story” of your presentation.
- Then each assertion should receive one dedicated slide in the presentation.

Assertion-Evidence Approach

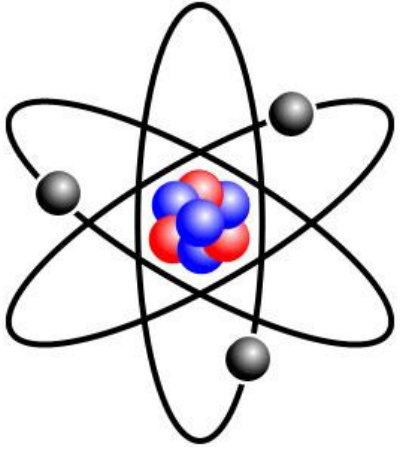
- On each slide, the title should directly be the assertion itself.
  - This could even be a full sentence!
  - It should be specific to the presentation and descriptive.
  - The audience can read the assertion and/or the speaker can read it out loud.
- The assertion of the slide is like the topic sentence of a paragraph.

Assertion-Evidence Approach

- Then, the rest of the slide should primarily be graphics which provide evidence (support) for the assertion.
- This does not mean there can't be any text on the slide, but it does suggest trying to minimize the amount of text in favor of graphics (pictures, charts, diagrams, schematics, maybe a table, etc.).

Example

Nuclear energy is the energy that holds protons and neutrons together in the nucleus of an atom



Atz, Emil, & Nomin Munkhbat . Nuclear Power. Storrs, CT: University of Connecticut, Engineering Ambassador, 2016

Assertion-Evidence Approach

- There is another slide deck on the TCL08 page on Carmen with additional examples.
- You can also look up this strategy online for more instructions / ideas.

Assertion-Evidence Approach

- You are encouraged to use the assertion-evidence approach in your capstone presentation slides.
- The main suggestions to follow are:
  - Each slide is about one main assertion (topic).
  - Slide titles should be specific and descriptive (instead of generic and bland).
  - Text should be minimized (but can be included).
  - Graphics should be used as evidence as much as possible.

Assertion-Evidence Approach

- This does not mean that you can't have bullet points of text or can't have any slides that are mostly text.
- It also does not mean that every single title needs to be a full sentence.
  - For example, "Requirements Table" is perfectly acceptable because that refers to a particular design step.
  - But "Problem Statement" could probably be changed to some specific assertion about your problem.
- It also does not mean that you should have decorative/extra graphics just to fill up slides.

Assertion-Evidence Approach

- Instead, the suggestion is to follow these practices as much as possible or as much as makes sense for your project and presentation.

Preparing for PDR Presentation

Audience

- Keep your audience in mind when preparing your PDR presentation slides.
- What information needs to be explained to make sure everyone knows?
- What is the most important information that the audience will want to know?

Include Only the Most Important Information

- Carefully consider the most important information to include on the slides
- You should be able to verbally explain everything in more detail than is on the slides so that the audience is mostly listening to and just referring to the visuals to complement what you are saying.
- You may need to cut out content for time (and be prepared to answer questions about it instead).

Prepare for the Q&A

- Prepare your team for likely questions.
- Plan who on the team will field questions.
- Repeat and re-state the question so everyone on the team and in the audience can hear it.
- Keep answers short and to-the-point.
  - You are still in front of the whole audience.
  - One-on-one discussions can happen after the talk.

Prepare for the Q&A

- Think about material you cut out for time.
- Think about what the audience may want.
- Sometimes you might encourage particular questions.
- You might want to buy time to think, but don't want to appear to avoid a question.
- You can rotate who on the team answers.
- Present a united front.

Prepare to Not Know Something

- Be willing to say you do not know.
  - Don't make up something or act like you know when you don't.
- Some phrasing you could consider:
  - "I haven't looked at that aspect."
  - "I'm not familiar enough with that to give you a good answer right now."
  - "That would be an interesting question to look into in the future."
  - "I don't know, but maybe someone else here can answer that."

PDR Presentations Coming Up

- Refer to the instructions / guidelines / rubrics provided on the project assignment.
- Be prepared to give your best presentation with your best-looking slides!
- Refer to the Assertion-Evidence Approach slides on Carmen for examples.